

**Board 1**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ Q T 4  
♥ J 9 8  
♦ Q J 4  
♣ J T 7 2

♠ K 7 5 2

♥ 6 4

♦ A 8 3

♣ A K 6 4



♠ J 6

♥ Q T 5 3

♦ K T 7 2

♣ Q 9 5

♠ A 9 8 3

♥ A K 7 2

♦ 9 6 5

♣ 8 3

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
|          | 1 ♣   | Pass | 1 ♥   |
| Pass     | 1 ♠   | Pass | 3 ♠   |
| Pass     | 4 ♠   |      |       |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

4 ♠ by North

Partner accepts the invitation.

South would play 4 ♠.

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North plays 4 ♠. East leads the ♦ 2. West plays ♦ J.

North plays 4 ♠. East leads the ♦ 2. West plays ♦ J.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 5

Counting losers from the North hand you have 2 ♣ losers to get rid of. If you had counted from the South hand there would have been 2 ♥ losers to get rid of. In any case the plan is the same.

Win the ♦ A and play ♠ A and ♠ K. If the ♠ s split 3-2 you are home-free. Leave the master trump out and play your ♣ A K and dummy's ♥ A K. Then cross-ruff ♣ s and ♥ s. Whichever defender holds the last trump is welcome to ruff with it at any time. The defense is also welcome to take their 2 ♦ s at any time. Your 10 tricks are safe.

This is another example of the general principle to leave a master trump out.

South and North were able to make all their small trumps individually.

If West ruffs the fourth ♥ with his master ♠ Q North just discards a ♦ loser and makes an overtrick.

There is an excellent bidding guideline which tells you how to respond with two 4-card Majors. You bid them "up-the-line". That means you bid 1 ♥.

Partner's rebid is 1 ♠.

This hand shows why responder should bid "up-the-line". Partner can now show a 4-card ♠ suit at the 1-level. Imagine the suits reversed - you first respond with 1 ♠. If partner wanted to show a ♥ suit he would have to go to the 2-level, and he might not have the strength to do so.

Back to the actual situation. Over partner's 1 ♠ bid you jump to 3 ♠. This jump shows about 11-12 points and good ♠ support (4 cards). In case you thought this showed 13 or more points that wouldn't be logical. If you had 13 points and 4 ♠ s you would jump all the way to game. So 3 ♠ is invitational.

**Board 2**

East Deals

None Vul

♠ K 6 5 2

♥ Q J T 2

♦ Q 7 3

♣ Q 8

♠ J 4

♥ 6 5 3

♦ J 4

♣ A K 9 6 5 2



♠ Q T 7

♥ 9 8 4

♦ K T 5 2

♣ J T 3

♠ A 9 8 3

♥ A K 7

♦ A 9 8 6

♣ 7 4

West

North

East

South

Pass

3NT

Pass

1NT

All Pass

3NT by South

the ♣s split 3-2, which is very likely, you can set up the tricks you need. **BUT**, if you just play ♣A ♣K and then a small one you'll be sorry. Those extra three ♣s will be established as winners but you will have no entry to them.

Instead, you play your ♣4 to the second trick and also play a low card from dummy. This is called Ducking the trick. East/West will certainly win that trick, but you are in control. You can win whatever suit they play and you still have that ♣7 to reach dummy's solid ♣s.

You can see that with ♣s splitting 3-2 the Duck insures the contract.

But just imagine you had played ♣A, ♣K, ♣2. At that point ♣ 9 6 5 would all be winners, but don't think East is going to let you reach dummy with either of those two Jacks!

You have 15 points and you have a balanced distribution. You should open 1NT. It is true that you do not have ♣s stopped, but you are not required to have a stopper in all the suits to open 1NT. Partner jumps to 3NT and you pass.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

**South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.**

Winner count: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 2 : Total = 6

In many Notrump hands it is good to hold up to disrupt the defender's communications. In this hand you have a double-stopper in ♥s but only a single stop in ♠s and ♦s so win the first trick.

You need 3 more tricks from the ♣ suit. As long as

**Board 3**

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ J 8 6 3 2  
 ♥ Q T 8 4  
 ♦ 9 8 3  
 ♣ A

♠ 9

♥ A 9 3

♦ K 5 2

♣ K J T 9 6 2

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ A Q T 5

♥ J 7 6 2

♦ Q J T 7

♣ 5

♠ K 7 4

♥ K 5

♦ A 6 4

♣ Q 8 7 4 3

|          |       |      |       |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
| West     | North | East | South |
| Pass     | 1 ♣   | Pass | 3 ♣   |
| Pass     | 5 ♣   |      |       |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

5 ♣ by North

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3

Is there any doubt? Although you only have 11 HCP your 6-card suit adds 2 more. And with 13 points you should always open. So you open 1 ♣.

Partner responds 3 ♣.

With the ♣ fit your hand is now revalued to 15 points. But it's still a close thing. You may be able to make 5 ♣ or you may not.

Passing would not be horrible - but when in doubt it is usually better to be bold. You cross your fingers and bid 5 ♣.

North plays 5 ♣. East leads the ♦ Q.

**North plays 5 ♣. East leads the ♦ Q.**

The two black Aces aren't going away so if you are to make this contract you must do something about your ♦ loser. And the only likely place to put it is on dummy's ♠ K. If East has the ♠ A, you can lead up to the ♠ K and make a winner out of it.

Suppose you win the ♦ Q in dummy and play a ♣. Somebody will win the ♣ A and play another ♦. You win this and lead toward the ♠ K. No good. East jumps up with his ♠ A and sets you with a ♦ winner.

The problem was that when you played a trump you let the timing go to the defense. They could knock out your last ♦ stopper while they still had the ♠ A. Try it this way.

Win the ♦ in your hand and immediately play the ♠ 9. If East doesn't take his ♠ A he'll never get it, so assume he goes up. Now he leads ♦ J but you win, get to dummy with the ♥ K and play the ♠ K, discarding the ♦ loser.

Pulling trumps is very important, but sometimes there is something you must do **BEFORE** you play trumps.

In this hand that something is to establish the ♠ K so you can discard your ♦ loser.

**Board 4**

East Deals

None Vul

♠ T 9 8 7

♥ A

♦ T 6 5

♣ J 9 5 4 2

♠ Q J 5

♥ J 8 7 3

♦ Q 7 4

♣ K Q T



♠ K 4 2

♥ 5 2

♦ 9 8 3 2

♣ A 7 6 3

♠ A 6 3

♥ K Q T 9 6 4

♦ A K J

♣ 8

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
| Pass     |       | Pass | 1♥    |
| Pass     | 3♥    | Pass | 4NT   |
| Pass     | 5♣    | Pass | 5♥    |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

5♥ by South

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3

You have a very good hand. But not good enough to open 2♣, so you open 1♥.

Partner jumps to 3♥.

This is close. Partner has 11 or 12 points and good ♥ support. Your hand revalues to 21 points. You might have a slam. You decide to try for it and bid 4NT. Partner replies 5♣ showing no Aces. So much for the slam. You bid 5♥.

South plays 5♥. West leads the ♠T. You put on dummy's ♠J, East plays the ♠K and you win the ♠A.

**South plays 5♥. West leads the ♠T. You put on dummy's ♠J, East plays the ♠K and you win the ♠A.**

You cannot avoid losing either of the two Aces. So therefore you must do something about the ♠ loser. And the only thing you can do with it is to discard it on one of dummy's ♣s.

Be careful. If you lead a trump now a defender will take the Ace and play another ♠, exposing your loser while the ♣A is still out. You must set up the ♣ first. So at trick 2 play your ♣ to dummy's ♣Q. A defender may win this and play a ♠, but you win the ♠Q and play the ♣K, discarding your ♠ loser. Now you switch to trumps.

The way you decide whether to start pulling trumps right away is to use your imagination.

Imagine what the defense will do if you lead a round of trumps. Then imagine what they will do if you play a different suit instead.

**Board 5**

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K T 9 8

♥ 9 6 3

♦ Q J 4

♣ 9 7 2

♠ Q J 7 4

♥ A K

♦ T 8 6 2

♣ A K Q



♠ 5 2

♥ Q J T 8 4

♦ K 9

♣ J 8 6 3

♠ A 6 3

♥ 7 5 2

♦ A 7 5 3

♣ T 5 4

West

North

East

South

Pass

1♦

Pass

2♦

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

This is one of the most misplayed positions in bridge. The usual approach is to lead the ♠Q, hoping that East holds the ♠K. But this can't succeed. If East does hold the ♠K he will cover, either this trick or the ♠J, and someone's ♠T will become a winner. Of course if West has the ♠K then the finesse will fail, along with your chance of 2 more winners.

The correct way to play for 2 more tricks is to hope **WEST** has the ♠K and lead twice toward your ♠Q J. So win the first trick, play ♠4 to dummy's ♠A. Lead the ♠3 toward your hand, playing the ♠J if West plays low. (Of course if West ever plays the ♠K he gives you two winners immediately.) When the ♠J wins, return to dummy with the ♦A and lead the ♠6 toward your ♠Q.

When West holds the ♠K you can always get 3 ♠ tricks if you play correctly.

With 19 points you are too strong to open 1NT so you open 1♦. Partner responds 2♦.

Perhaps you can make 5♦. But 9 tricks are easier than 11 so you bid 3NT. Notice that there was no reason to "show" your ♠ suit. If partner held 4 ♠s he would not have bid 2♦.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

**North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.**

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 3 : Total = 7

You can create one winner in ♦s if they split 3-2, but too late, the defense would have set up their ♥s. So you must get 2 more ♠ tricks.